



Introduction: Why Your Stories Matter as Much as Your Skills

I joined Amazon as a software engineer nearly twenty years ago. In that time, I conducted nearly a thousand interviews across the full range of technical hiring, I became a Bar Raiser, and I trained thousands of people on how to conduct technical interviews. I've watched the interview process for our industry evolve from pure whiteboard coding and brain-teasers to today's mix of technical and behavioral assessments. I've seen technically strong candidates get rejected while others with similar technical skills received surprising offers.

The difference in hiring outcomes often came down to how well each candidate had told their stories about their experience.

I remember one particular occasion when I was interviewing two senior engineer candidates. Both of them had sailed through the coding problems and had delivered solid system design solutions. But when I asked each of them to recount a time when they had disagreed with their teams on a technical decision, their responses were revealing.

Candidate 1 described how he had presented the pros and cons for his position, and he articulated clearly why the others in his team had held opposing views. He disagreed with them, but he understood their reasoning.

company. You can imagine who got the offer.

Over the years, a problem has developed in that technical interviews have become the be-all and end-all in our industry. Online platforms offer endless practice problems. System design resources are everywhere. The technical bar remains high, but it has become more standardized and easier to prepare for.

This creates a challenge for companies. If most qualified candidates can clear the technical bar, how do companies identify which candidates will thrive in their specific environment, and at what level?

Many companies now recognize that the behavioral interview has become the critical differentiator. Google uses behavioral questions to evaluate "Googleness". Meta aims to assess if candidates "Move Fast" and "Build Social Value." Microsoft looks for "Growth Mindset" in the stories that candidates tell them.

Those companies understand that technical excellence alone doesn't predict success. They need people who can handle ambiguity, influence without authority, learn from failures, and increase the effectiveness of those around them.

Most technical professionals will spend months grinding through coding problems and studying system design. Then they will spend maybe an hour thinking about behavioral questions. But such an imbalanced preparation can be costly. When the technical skills of candidates are comparable, behavioral interviews will often determine who gets the offer. Strong behavioral performances can tip the scales for candidates who are on the fence technically. On the other hand, poor behavioral performances filled with red flags can sink even those who ace the technical portions.

How you tell the story of your experience determines more than just whether you will get hired. It also helps determine at what level you will get hired. Getting down-leveled costs more than pride; it also affects your compensation, career trajectory, and daily work satisfaction. In US tech companies, the difference between mid- and senior levels can mean \$100,000 per year or more. Even with strong performance, a promotion from a down-leveled position will typically take 18–36 months. During that time, you will have lost salary, stock appreciation, and bonuses, and the compounding effect of raises from a lower base will be smaller than if you had not been down-leveled.

But the financial hit is only part of the story. Being down-leveled attacks your professional identity. Your scope shrinks. You now have to contribute to projects you once would have led. The more interesting, impactful work goes to others. This frustration can affect your motivation and performance, making that eventual promotion even harder to achieve. Everyone wins when you get leveled correctly from the start.

systems. It also means working with other people to turn technical work into business results. This becomes especially true at senior levels and beyond, where behavioral competencies often matter more for leveling decisions than the ability to solve harder coding problems.

Behavioral interviews assess what you can do, based on what you've already done. When an interviewer asks you for examples to illustrate how you have dealt with ambiguous requirements, they want to know whether you can operate in the uncertain environments in which real technical work takes place. Interviewers are carefully evaluating how you work, how you make decisions, and whether you can actually deliver results.

This book will show you how to find the stories already sitting in your experience and how to tell them well. You'll learn what interviewers are listening for and how to frame your work at the level you're targeting. The work you put into this will pay off beyond interviews because the same thinking that makes you better at telling your story will make you better at doing your job.

The beautiful thing about behavioral interviews is that they reward genuine experience. You can't easily fake your way through them. They require you to reflect on your actual work, identify patterns in it, and communicate complex situations clearly. Incidentally, these are the same skills that make a person an effective technical professional.

Whether you're a software engineer, data scientist, product manager, or any other technical professional, your experiences contain powerful stories. The challenge is learning to spot them and tell them well.

Let's begin.

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Seattle, Washington

February 2026

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